



The Impact of Brand Equity Dimensions on Purchase Intention: Empirical Evidence from the Vietnamese Life Insurance Market

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Abstract

This study investigates the impact of brand equity dimensions - brand awareness, brand associations, perceived quality, and brand loyalty - on purchase intention in the Vietnamese life insurance market. Drawing upon Aaker's (1991) and Keller's (1993) customer-based brand equity framework and the Theory of Planned Behavior, the study employs a quantitative approach using survey data from 350 customers analyzed via SmartPLS 4. The results confirm that all four brand equity dimensions positively and significantly influence purchase intention, with brand loyalty exhibiting the strongest effect, followed by perceived quality, brand awareness, and brand associations. These findings highlight the dual cognitive - affective nature of brand equity, emphasizing that trust and emotional attachment are critical in shaping consumers' decisions for high-involvement financial services. The study contributes to the literature by validating the multidimensional brand equity model within an emerging Asian market context. Managerially, it underscores the importance of enhancing customer loyalty, ensuring service reliability, and maintaining transparent communication to foster long-term trust and brand sustainability in Vietnam's competitive life insurance industry.

Keywords: *Brand equity, Brand loyalty, Perceived quality, Purchase intention, Life insurance, Vietnam.*

JEL Classification codes: G22.

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Introduction

In recent years, brand equity has become a crucial strategic concept for firms seeking to create sustainable competitive advantages, particularly in service industries where intangible offerings make evaluation difficult prior to purchase. According to Aaker (1991), brand equity represents a set of brand assets and liabilities linked to a brand's name and symbol that add to or subtract from the value provided by a product or service (Negash, 2018). Similarly, Keller (1993) conceptualized customer-based brand equity (CBBE) as the differential effect of brand knowledge on consumer response to marketing activities. These perspectives highlight that strong brand equity can influence consumer perceptions, preferences, and ultimately purchase intentions (Yoo & Donthu, 2001; Buil et al., 2013).

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The insurance industry provides a compelling context for studying brand equity because of its high involvement and risk-perception nature. Unlike tangible goods, life insurance products are complex, long-term commitments whose benefits cannot be directly experienced at the point of purchase. Therefore, customers rely heavily on brand cues as signals of credibility, reliability, and quality (Erdem & Swait, 2004; Dawes et al., 2015). A strong brand can reduce perceived risk, increase trust, and enhance consumers' willingness to purchase insurance services (Delgado-Ballester & Munuera-Alemán, 2005; de Chernatony & McDonald, 2003).

Vietnam's life insurance market has undergone rapid expansion over the past decade, reflecting the country's economic growth and rising middle class. According to the Ministry of Finance of Vietnam (2023), the total premium revenue of the life insurance sector reached over VND 180 trillion in 2022, accounting for nearly 70% of the insurance market's total revenue. Despite this remarkable growth, the market remains highly competitive, with more than 20 domestic and foreign life insurers vying for customer trust and loyalty. In such an environment, brand equity serves as a critical differentiator that can shape consumers' purchase intentions and foster long-term relationships.

While numerous studies have examined brand equity in sectors such as fast-moving consumer goods (Yoo & Donthu, 2001; Buil et al., 2013) and retail services (Pappu et al., 2005), empirical evidence from the life insurance industry - especially in emerging markets like Vietnam - remains scarce. Moreover, given the unique cultural and behavioral characteristics of Vietnamese consumers, including a high level of uncertainty avoidance and strong reliance on interpersonal trust (Hofstede Insights, 2023), the dynamics between brand equity dimensions and purchase intention may differ from those observed in Western contexts.

Against this background, the present study aims to examine the impact of brand equity dimensions - brand awareness, brand associations, perceived quality, and brand loyalty - on purchase intention in the Vietnamese life insurance market. Drawing on Aaker's (1991) and Keller's (1993) frameworks of brand equity and grounded in the Theory of Planned Behavior (Ajzen, 1991), the study develops and tests a conceptual model using survey data from customers of Hanwha Life Vietnam. By identifying the relative importance of brand equity components, this research contributes to the literature by extending the applicability of brand equity theories to a service context in an emerging market. From a managerial perspective, the findings will provide actionable insights for insurance firms to strengthen brand positioning, improve perceived quality, and foster customer loyalty.

Literature Review and Hypotheses Development

Brand Equity and Its Dimensions

Brand equity has been recognized as a multidimensional construct that represents the value added to a product or service by its brand name (Aaker, 1991; Keller, 1993). From a customer-based perspective, brand equity captures consumers' perceptions and responses to brand-related stimuli (Keller, 2003). Aaker (1991) proposed four key dimensions of brand equity: brand awareness, brand associations, perceived quality, and brand loyalty. Together, these dimensions explain how consumers evaluate brands and how such evaluations influence their behavioral intentions (Yoo & Donthu, 2001).

Empirical studies have consistently demonstrated that strong brand equity leads to favorable consumer attitudes and behavioral outcomes, including higher satisfaction, trust, and purchase intention (Pappu, Quester & Cooksey, 2005; Buil, de Chernatony & Martínez, 2013). In the context of services, particularly financial and insurance services, brand equity serves as a signal of credibility



and risk reduction (Erdem & Swait, 2004). The following subsections review each dimension of brand equity and its hypothesized relationship with purchase intention.

Brand Awareness and Purchase Intention

Brand awareness refers to the ability of consumers to recognize and recall a brand under different conditions (Keller, 1993). It reflects the strength of a brand's presence in consumers' minds and influences how likely it is to be considered during purchase decisions (Percy & Rossiter, 1992). When consumers are familiar with a brand, they tend to perceive it as more reliable and trustworthy, especially in high-risk service contexts such as insurance (Rossiter & Percy, 1997). Prior research confirms that higher brand awareness increases consumers' confidence and reduces perceived risk, thereby enhancing their intention to purchase (Huang & Sarigöllü, 2012; Foroudi et al., 2018).

H1: Brand awareness has a positive effect on purchase intention.

Brand Associations and Purchase Intention

Brand associations encompass the meanings, images, and attributes linked to a brand in consumers' memory (Aaker, 1991; Keller, 1993). These associations may include perceptions of company reputation, product quality, emotional appeal, and social responsibility. In the life insurance sector, strong and favorable associations - such as trustworthiness, financial stability, and caring service - can significantly influence customer choice (Low & Lamb, 2000; Chen, 2001). Empirical evidence suggests that brand associations play a critical role in shaping consumers' perceived value and purchase intention (Agarwal & Rao, 1996; Tong & Hawley, 2009).

H2: Brand associations have a positive effect on purchase intention.

Perceived Quality and Purchase Intention

Perceived quality is defined as the consumer's judgment about the overall excellence or superiority of a product or service (Zeithaml, 1988). It represents the customer's subjective evaluation rather than an objective assessment of quality. In services like insurance, perceived quality is particularly salient because consumers face uncertainty regarding the provider's reliability and performance. Studies have shown that perceived quality not only enhances customer satisfaction but also builds trust and willingness to purchase (Yoo, Donthu & Lee, 2000; Buil et al., 2013). In Vietnam's life insurance market, where information asymmetry and skepticism toward service providers remain prevalent, perceived quality is expected to be a decisive determinant of purchase intention.

H3: Perceived quality has a positive effect on purchase intention.

Brand Loyalty and Purchase Intention

Brand loyalty represents a consumer's commitment to repurchase or continue using a brand's products or services in the future (Oliver, 1999). Loyal customers are less sensitive to price changes and more resistant to competitive offerings (Chaudhuri & Holbrook, 2001). In the insurance context, loyalty reflects long-term relationships built on satisfaction, trust, and positive prior experiences (Mittal & Kamakura, 2001). High brand loyalty not only increases repeat purchases but also enhances word-of-mouth and brand advocacy (Dick & Basu, 1994). Numerous studies have confirmed a strong and direct relationship between brand loyalty and purchase intention across various industries (Yoo & Donthu, 2001; Nam, Ekinci & Whyatt, 2011).

H4: Brand loyalty has a positive effect on purchase intention.

Conceptual Framework

Based on the above literature, this study conceptualizes a model linking four dimensions of brand equity - brand awareness, brand associations, perceived quality, and brand loyalty - to purchase intention in the Vietnamese life insurance market. The model draws upon the customer-based



brand equity framework (Aaker, 1991; Keller, 1993) and integrates behavioral insights from the Theory of Planned Behavior (Ajzen, 1991), which suggests that favorable brand beliefs and attitudes influence consumers' behavioral intentions. Figure 1 illustrates the proposed conceptual framework and hypothesized relationships among constructs.

Research Methodology

Research Design

This study adopts a quantitative research design to empirically examine the relationships between the dimensions of brand equity and purchase intention in the Vietnamese life insurance market. Given the explanatory nature of the research model, a cross-sectional survey was conducted among individual customers of Hanwha Life Vietnam, one of the leading life insurance providers in the country. The quantitative approach was selected because it allows for testing hypothesized causal relationships between constructs and generalizing findings across a larger population (Hair, Hult, Ringle, & Sarstedt, 2021).

The study follows the variance-based structural equation modeling (PLS-SEM) technique using SmartPLS 4 software. PLS-SEM is appropriate when the research objective is theory development rather than theory confirmation, and when the model includes multiple latent constructs measured by several indicators (Hair et al., 2021; Ringle, Wende, & Becker, 2015). This method also accommodates non-normal data distributions and moderate sample sizes, making it suitable for consumer survey data collected in emerging markets such as Vietnam.

Sampling and Data Collection

The target population comprised individual customers who have purchased or considered purchasing life insurance policies from Hanwha Life Vietnam. A purposive sampling method was employed to ensure that respondents possessed relevant knowledge and experience with the brand. Data were collected through a structured questionnaire distributed both online and in person between April and June 2024.

A total of 400 questionnaires were distributed, of which 362 were returned and 350 were deemed valid for analysis after screening for completeness and response quality. This sample size satisfies the minimum sample requirement for PLS-SEM, following the “10-times rule” (Hair et al., 2019), as well as recommendations for achieving statistical power above 0.80 (Cohen, 1992). Respondents represented diverse demographic profiles, including gender, age, income, and duration of insurance participation, ensuring heterogeneity of perspectives.

Measurement Instruments

All constructs in this study were measured using multi-item scales adapted from prior validated research, with minor contextual adjustments for the insurance sector in Vietnam. Each item was rated on a five-point Likert scale ranging from 1 (“strongly disagree”) to 5 (“strongly agree”) (Luo, et al., 2024).

Table 1. Measurement Items

Code	Statement	Source (author, year)
Brand Awareness (BA)		
BA1	I am aware of several life insurance brands available in Vietnam.	Yoo & Donthu (2001)
BA2	I can recognize a life insurance company's name or logo when I see it.	Keller (1993); Yoo & Donthu (2001)



BAS3	When someone mentions “life insurance,” I can quickly recall specific brand names.	Keller (1993)
BAS4	I have seen advertising or communications from life insurance companies in Vietnam that I remember.	Buil, de Chernatony & Martínez (2013)
Brand Associations (BAS)		
BAS1	I associate life insurance companies in Vietnam with financial stability and trust.	Aaker (1991); Chen (2001)
BAS2	Life insurance brands convey images of professional and caring service.	Chen (2001); Low & Lamb (2000)
BAS3	I associate leading life insurers with clear and positive corporate reputation.	Low & Lamb (2000)
BAS4	I associate life insurance brands with helpful and understandable product information.	Keller (1993); Aaker (1991)
BAS5	I perceive some life insurance brands as socially responsible (e.g., customer-care, community programs).	Buil et al. (2013)
Perceived Quality (PQ)		
PQ1	In general, life insurance companies in Vietnam provide high-quality service.	Zeithaml (1988); Yoo, Donthu & Lee (2000)
PQ2	Life insurance companies deliver on the service promises they make to customers.	Zeithaml (1988)
PQ3	Compared with other financial service providers, life insurers in Vietnam offer superior product/service quality.	Buil et al. (2013); Yoo et al. (2000)
PQ4	The processes (e.g., claims handling, policy servicing) of life insurers are reliable and consistent.	Zeithaml (1988)
Brand Loyalty (BL)		
BL1	If I currently hold a life insurance policy, I intend to renew it with the same company.	Oliver (1999)
BL2	I would recommend my life insurance provider to friends or family.	Chaudhuri & Holbrook (2001)
BL3	I prefer to continue with my current life insurer even if other companies offer similar policies.	Yoo & Donthu (2001)
BL4	I consider myself loyal to at least one life insurance brand in Vietnam.	Oliver (1999)
Purchase Intention (PI)		
PI1	I intend to purchase a life insurance policy from a reputable life insurance company in Vietnam within the next 12 months.	Dodds, Monroe & Grewal (1991); Pappu et al. (2005)
PI2	I am likely to consider buying life insurance from companies that have strong brand reputations.	Buil et al. (2013)
PI3	I would choose a well-known life insurance brand over an unknown company when purchasing a policy.	Dodds et al. (1991)
PI4	It is likely that I will recommend buying life insurance to others based on brand impressions.	Pappu et al. (2005)

The questionnaire was first developed in English, then translated into Vietnamese following a back-translation procedure (Brislin, 1980) to ensure conceptual and linguistic equivalence. A pilot test was conducted with 30 respondents to check clarity, relevance, and reliability. Based on feedback, minor wording adjustments were made to improve comprehension.

Data Analysis Procedure

Data analysis proceeded in two main stages: (1) assessment of the measurement model and (2) evaluation of the structural model (Hair et al., 2021).

In the measurement model assessment, internal consistency reliability was evaluated using Cronbach's alpha and composite reliability (CR), both of which should exceed 0.70 (Nunnally & Bernstein, 1994). Convergent validity was examined via factor loadings (>0.70) and average



variance extracted ($AVE > 0.50$), while discriminant validity was verified using the heterotrait–monotrait ratio ($HTMT < 0.85$) (Henseler, Ringle, & Sarstedt, 2015).

For the structural model assessment, path coefficients and coefficient of determination (R^2) were estimated to assess the predictive power of the model. The significance of hypothesized relationships was tested through a bootstrapping procedure with 5,000 resamples. Additionally, effect sizes (f^2) and predictive relevance (Q^2) were computed to evaluate the magnitude and predictive accuracy of the model (Chin, 1998). Multicollinearity was assessed using variance inflation factors ($VIF < 5$), confirming the absence of collinearity issues.

Ethical Considerations

Participation in the study was voluntary, and all respondents were informed of the research purpose and confidentiality of their responses. No identifying personal data were collected. Ethical approval was obtained from the research committee of the authors' affiliated university prior to data collection, in accordance with standard research ethics procedures.

Results

Sample Characteristics

A total of 350 valid responses were collected from individual customers with experience purchasing or considering life insurance in Vietnam. Among respondents, 52.6% were female and 47.4% were male. The majority of respondents were between 25 and 44 years old (61.2%), followed by those aged 45–60 (27.5%) and those under 25 years old (11.3%). In terms of income, 57.7% earned between 10 and 25 million VND per month, 22.3% earned above 25 million VND, and 20.0% earned below 10 million VND. Regarding insurance experience, 63% had already purchased at least one life insurance policy, while 37% were potential customers who were considering buying one. More than half of respondents (54.9%) reported that they had known about their insurance provider for more than three years, suggesting that participants were sufficiently informed to evaluate brand-related factors.

These characteristics indicate that the sample is well distributed and representative of the Vietnamese life insurance market, where brand equity and customer loyalty play important roles in shaping purchasing behavior.

Table 2. Respondents' Information

Variable	Category	Frequency (n)	Percentage (%)
Gender	Male	166	47.4
	Female	184	52.6
Age group	Under 25 years	40	11.3
	25–44 years	214	61.2
	45–60 years	96	27.5
Monthly income (VND)	< 10 million	70	20.0
	10–25 million	202	57.7
	> 25 million	78	22.3
Experience with life insurance	Already purchased	221	63.1
	Considering purchase	129	36.9
Duration of relationship with insurer	< 1 year	64	18.3
	1–3 years	94	26.8
	> 3 years	192	54.9

Source: Authors' survey data (2024).



Measurement Model Evaluation

The measurement model was evaluated in terms of internal consistency reliability, convergent validity, and collinearity diagnostics. As shown in Table 3, all outer loadings ranged from 0.804 to 0.889, exceeding the recommended threshold of 0.70 (Hair et al., 2021), demonstrating good indicator reliability. Cronbach's alpha coefficients for all constructs were above 0.86, with the highest value being 0.904 (BA), confirming internal consistency reliability. Composite reliability (CR) values ranged from 0.906 to 0.932, all exceeding 0.70, further indicating construct reliability. Convergent validity was confirmed as all Average Variance Extracted (AVE) values exceeded 0.50, ranging from 0.707 (PI) to 0.775 (BA), satisfying the Fornell–Larcker criterion. Variance Inflation Factor (VIF) values for individual items were between 1.902 and 2.715, all well below the threshold of 3.0, indicating the absence of multicollinearity issues.

Table 3. Measurement Model Summary

Construct	Outer Loading Range	Cronbach's α	CR	AVE	VIF Range
Brand Awareness (BA)	0.867–0.888	0.904	0.932	0.775	2.50–2.72
Brand Associations (BAS)	0.804–0.879	0.902	0.927	0.717	2.06–2.52
Brand Loyalty (BL)	0.859–0.879	0.889	0.923	0.751	2.25–2.53
Purchase Intention (PI)	0.821–0.858	0.862	0.906	0.707	1.90–2.21
Perceived Quality (PQ)	0.843–0.889	0.891	0.925	0.754	2.18–2.66

Discriminant Validity

Discriminant validity was examined using both the Fornell–Larcker criterion and the Heterotrait–Monotrait (HTMT) ratio. The square roots of the AVE values (diagonal elements in Table 4) were higher than the inter-construct correlations, satisfying the Fornell–Larcker criterion (Liu, et al., 2025). Furthermore, all HTMT values were below the conservative threshold of 0.85 (Henseler, Ringle, & Sarstedt, 2015; Liu, et al., 2025), ranging from 0.036 to 0.520, confirming discriminant validity among constructs.

Table 4. Discriminant Validity (HTMT and Fornell–Larcker Results)

Constructs	BA	BAS	BL	PI	PQ
HTMT					
BA	—	0.119	0.054	0.342	0.047
BAS		—	0.036	0.338	0.077
BL			—	0.520	0.075
PI				—	0.392
PQ					—
Fornell–Larcker ($\sqrt{\text{AVE}}$)	0.880	0.847	0.866	0.841	0.869

These results indicate that each construct captures a unique concept distinct from other variables in the model.

Structural Model Evaluation

Collinearity among latent variables was tested and found to be acceptable, with construct-level VIF values between 1.007 and 1.018, far below the critical value of 3. The model's predictive accuracy and relevance were assessed using R^2 and Q^2 values. As shown in Table 5, the endogenous construct Purchase Intention (PI) recorded $R^2 = 0.477$ and adjusted $R^2 = 0.471$, indicating that 47.7% of the variance in purchase intention is explained by the four brand equity dimensions (BA,



BAS, PQ, BL). The cross-validated redundancy value $Q^2 = 0.460$ (>0) demonstrates strong predictive relevance of the model. Additionally, the model's goodness of fit was supported by the SRMR value of 0.040, which is below the threshold of 0.08 (Henseler et al., 2014).

Table 5. Structural Model Summary (R^2 , Q^2 , SRMR)

Endogenous Construct	R^2	Adjusted R^2	Q^2	SRMR
Purchase Intention (PI)	0.477	0.471	0.460	0.040

These results suggest that the model demonstrates satisfactory explanatory and predictive power in the context of Vietnam's life insurance market.

Hypothesis Testing

The significance of the hypothesized relationships was assessed using the bootstrapping method with 5,000 resamples. All path coefficients were found to be positive and statistically significant at the 0.001 level, confirming that each brand equity dimension has a meaningful influence on purchase intention.

Table 6. Hypothesis Testing Results

Path	β (Original Sample)	t-Statistic	F^2	p-Value	Supported
H1: Brand Awareness $\rightarrow$ Purchase Intention	0.288	7.815	0.156	0.000	Yes
H2: Brand Associations $\rightarrow$ Purchase Intention	0.263	6.273	0.130	0.000	Yes
H3: Perceived Quality $\rightarrow$ Purchase Intention	0.291	7.577	0.160	0.000	Yes
H4: Brand Loyalty $\rightarrow$ Purchase Intention	0.457	12.525	0.396	0.000	Yes

Among the predictors, Brand Loyalty ($\beta = 0.457$) exhibited the strongest effect on Purchase Intention, followed by Perceived Quality ($\beta = 0.291$), Brand Awareness ($\beta = 0.288$), and Brand Associations ($\beta = 0.263$). These findings suggest that while all brand equity dimensions contribute to shaping consumers' purchase intentions, loyalty and perceived quality are particularly decisive in the Vietnamese life insurance context.

Overall, the measurement model demonstrated high reliability and validity, while the structural model exhibited substantial explanatory power and predictive relevance. The results confirm that consumers' purchase intentions toward life insurance products in Vietnam are significantly influenced by their awareness, associations, perceived quality, and loyalty toward insurance brands—emphasizing the critical role of brand-building strategies in enhancing customer decisions and long-term competitiveness.



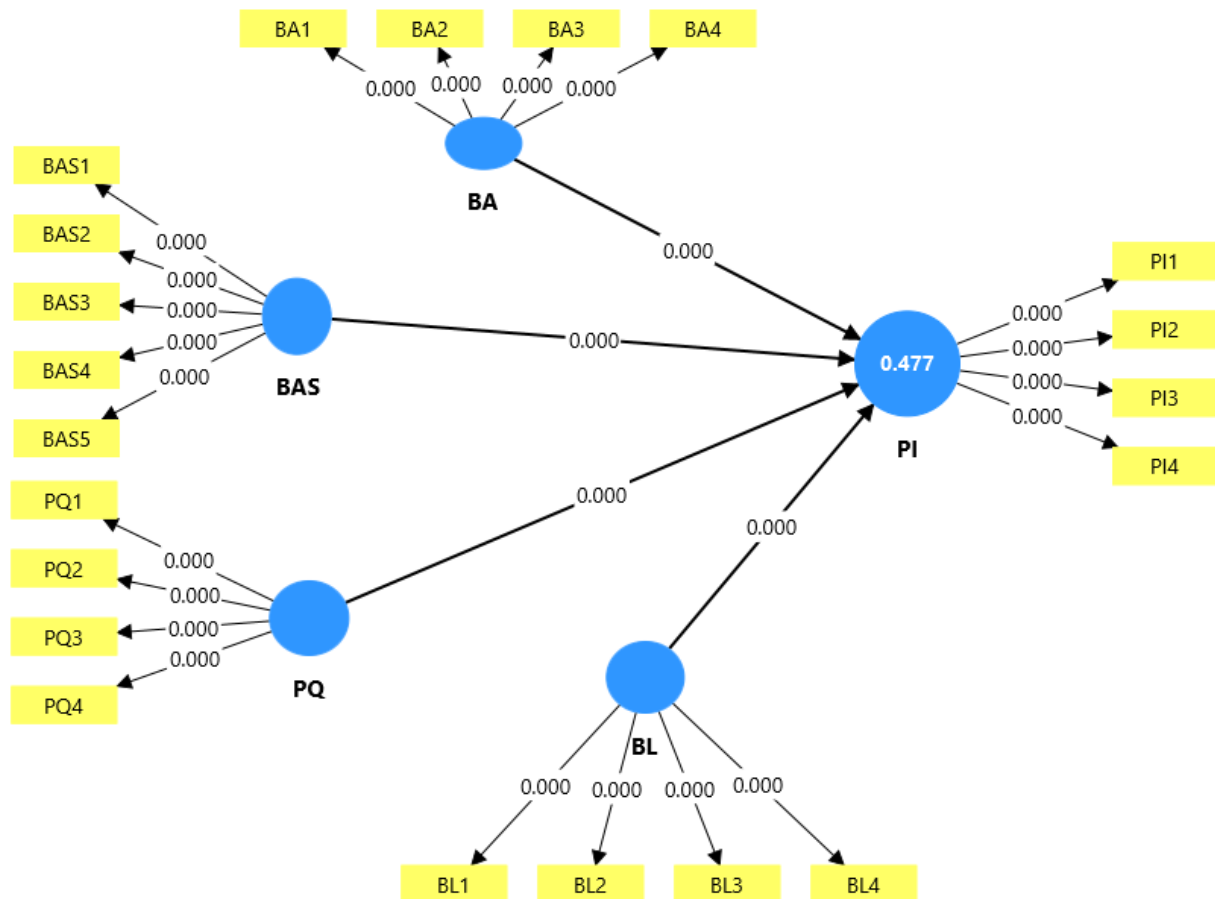


Figure 2. Structural Model

Discussion

The findings of this study provide strong empirical support for the proposed research model, confirming that all four dimensions of brand equity - brand awareness, brand associations, perceived quality, and brand loyalty - positively and significantly influence purchase intention in the Vietnamese life insurance market. These results are consistent with the theoretical foundations of Aaker's (1991) and Keller's (1993) brand equity frameworks, which posit that consumers' perceptions, experiences, and emotional attachment to a brand jointly determine their behavioral intentions.

Discussion of Key Findings

Among the four dimensions, brand loyalty emerged as the strongest predictor of purchase intention ($\beta = 0.457$, $p < 0.001$). This finding aligns with prior studies by Chaudhuri and Holbrook (2001), Pappu et al. (2005), and Buil et al. (2013), which emphasize that loyalty represents the most direct behavioral manifestation of brand equity. In the context of life insurance - a high-involvement, long-term service - customers tend to rely heavily on trust, satisfaction, and prior experiences. Loyalty, therefore, acts as a stabilizing mechanism that reduces perceived risk, encourages contract renewal, and strengthens word-of-mouth advocacy (Oliver, 1999).

In Vietnam, where financial literacy and service transparency are still developing, loyal customers often become informal brand ambassadors, influencing peers and family members' purchase decisions. Hence, loyalty not only reflects satisfaction but also encapsulates emotional



commitment, which is especially vital in financial service sectors characterized by intangible and trust-based offerings.

The second most influential factor, perceived quality ($\beta = 0.291$, $p < 0.001$), also exerts a strong effect on purchase intention. This result supports previous empirical evidence (e.g., Zeithaml, 1988; Yoo et al., 2000; Pappu et al., 2005) suggesting that perceived quality serves as a critical cognitive assessment that underpins trust and value perception in brand evaluation. In life insurance, perceived quality is manifested through service reliability, claims efficiency, staff professionalism, and transparent policy information. Vietnamese consumers often face difficulties evaluating life insurance benefits due to information asymmetry; therefore, high service quality reduces uncertainty and enhances confidence in purchasing decisions.

While brand awareness ($\beta = 0.288$) and brand associations ($\beta = 0.263$) have relatively smaller yet significant effects, they remain fundamental antecedents of brand-building. Awareness fosters recognition and familiarity, which are prerequisites for brand consideration and trust formation (Keller, 1993). Associations - such as perceptions of financial stability, reputation, and social responsibility - contribute to emotional differentiation and perceived credibility (Low & Lamb, 2000; Chen, 2001).

Collectively, these results indicate that both cognitive and affective components of brand equity operate synergistically to drive consumer intentions, confirming the multidimensional and interdependent nature of brand equity in the service sector.

Theoretical Implications

This study enriches brand equity research by validating Aaker's and Keller's conceptual frameworks in a developing Asian context characterized by trust-sensitive financial services. The empirical evidence demonstrates that brand loyalty and perceived quality are the most dominant components influencing behavioral intention, reinforcing the hierarchical brand equity model proposed by Cobb-Walgren et al. (1995), where loyalty and quality serve as outcome-oriented constructs reflecting deeper brand engagement.

Furthermore, by examining brand equity in the life insurance industry - a domain with long-term, risk-based customer relationships—this research extends the literature beyond the commonly studied fast-moving consumer goods and retail banking sectors, showing that brand equity functions similarly but with stronger emphasis on trust, assurance, and relationship continuity.

Managerial Implications

The empirical findings of this study offer several important managerial insights for life insurance companies operating in Vietnam. First, the dominant role of brand loyalty in shaping purchase intention suggests that insurers should focus on strengthening long-term customer relationships rather than short-term sales. Building loyalty requires consistent delivery of promises, transparent communication, and proactive customer support, particularly during the claims-handling process. Firms that maintain customer satisfaction throughout the policy lifecycle can transform existing clients into advocates who promote the brand through positive word-of-mouth, thereby reducing acquisition costs and enhancing reputation. Second, the strong influence of perceived quality indicates that customers value service excellence and reliability as the foundation for trust. Insurance providers should therefore prioritize service consistency, staff professionalism, and responsiveness, while leveraging digital technologies such as online policy management, automated claim systems, and AI-based advisory tools to enhance perceived efficiency and credibility. Third, although brand awareness and brand associations exhibit relatively weaker effects, they remain critical for establishing initial trust and consideration. Continuous brand communication emphasizing financial stability, customer care, and social responsibility can reinforce positive perceptions and foster emotional attachment. Companies that link their brand identity with



responsible business practices—such as supporting community well-being or promoting financial literacy—can cultivate more meaningful associations in the minds of Vietnamese consumers. Finally, strengthening collaboration with regulatory bodies and industry associations to ensure transparency in product information and claims performance may further enhance public trust in the industry as a whole. Overall, these managerial implications highlight that the sustainable development of life insurance brands in Vietnam depends not only on product innovation but also on consistent service quality, long-term relationship management, and an authentic, socially responsible brand image.

Summary

In summary, this study underscores that brand equity is not merely a marketing asset but a strategic determinant of purchasing behavior in Vietnam's life insurance sector. Companies that invest in long-term customer relationships and maintain superior perceived quality will be better positioned to sustain competitive advantage and market share. The findings provide actionable insights for insurers seeking to strengthen customer trust, enhance loyalty, and drive purchase intentions in a rapidly evolving and increasingly customer-centric financial environment.

Conclusion

This study set out to examine the impact of brand equity dimensions—brand awareness, brand associations, perceived quality, and brand loyalty—on purchase intention within the context of the Vietnamese life insurance market. Drawing upon the customer-based brand equity (CBBE) framework proposed by Aaker (1991) and Keller (1993), the research utilized quantitative data from 350 respondents analyzed through SmartPLS 4. The findings confirm that all dimensions of brand equity significantly and positively influence purchase intention, with brand loyalty and perceived quality emerging as the two most powerful determinants. These results validate the multidimensional structure of brand equity and highlight its pivotal role in driving consumer decisions in high-involvement and trust-dependent service sectors such as life insurance.

Theoretically, the study extends the literature on brand equity by empirically testing its dimensions in an emerging Asian market context, thereby reinforcing the universality of the CBBE model beyond Western markets. It also emphasizes that both cognitive and affective processes jointly shape consumers' behavioral intentions, with loyalty and quality reflecting outcome-oriented dimensions that bridge perception and commitment.

From a managerial perspective, the findings underscore the importance for insurers to invest in building and maintaining customer loyalty through reliable service, transparent communication, and long-term engagement strategies. Enhancing perceived quality through professional staff training, digitalization, and efficient claims handling can further strengthen consumer trust and willingness to purchase. While awareness and associations play supporting roles, their contribution to initial consideration and emotional differentiation should not be underestimated.

Despite its contributions, the study is not without limitations. The sample was restricted to Vietnamese customers, which may limit the generalizability of findings across other cultural or regional markets. Future research could incorporate comparative studies across ASEAN countries, apply longitudinal data to track changes in brand equity perception over time, or integrate moderating variables such as trust, digital experience, or regulatory confidence to deepen understanding of consumer decision mechanisms.

In conclusion, the results affirm that brand equity is not merely a marketing construct but a strategic asset that drives consumer behavior, strengthens organizational reputation, and ensures sustainable competitiveness in Vietnam's rapidly evolving life insurance industry.



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